

Vice Principal (Primary)

The Vice Principal is a pivotal leader within the primary academy, responsible for shaping and delivering a high-performing, inclusive culture across the school. As a senior leader, the role supports the Principal in strategic planning, operational effectiveness, and the personal and academic development of all pupils. In partnership with the Principal and wider leadership team, the post holder will champion high expectations, drive innovation, and support the delivery of the Trust's educational vision, ensuring its effective implementation within the primary setting.

Core Purpose

The ideal candidate will bring presence, passion and resilience to the role – demonstrating a relentless commitment to raising standards and transforming outcomes for all young learners. With a collaborative mindset, they will confidently lead and work as part of a team, build strong relationships with staff, pupils, parents, governors, and the wider community. They will remain calm under pressure, solve problems with creativity and care, and approach their work with empathy and integrity, always prioritising the needs of young children. Driven by improvement, innovation and inclusion, they will be self-reflective, organised, and strategic – maintaining attention to detail without losing sight of the bigger picture of providing an exceptional primary education. Above all, they will share our belief in education as a force for equity, and bring energy, humour and vision to everything they do, inspiring a love of learning in young minds.

Key Areas of Responsibility

1. Strategic Leadership and School Improvement

- **Work collaboratively with the Principal** to shape and communicate a compelling strategic vision that moves the academy towards Outstanding, specifically tailored to the primary context and the developmental needs of young children.
- **Lead on key areas of the Ofsted Education Inspection Framework (EIF)** and Academy Performance Agreement, ensuring they are implemented effectively and rigorously monitored, with a focus on their application within the primary phase.
- **Maintain a robust understanding of educational research and Ofsted expectations**, embedding self-review frameworks and quality assurance processes across the school, ensuring they are appropriate for evaluating primary practice.

- **Support the implementation of change** where necessary, demonstrating courage, clarity, and cohesion, while carefully considering the impact of change on young learners and their families.
- **Build capacity by developing high-performing teams** through coaching, mentoring, and tailored professional development, specifically designed to enhance primary pedagogy and practice.
- **Act as Principal when required**, providing confident and accountable leadership, with a clear understanding of the unique challenges and rewards of leading a primary school.

2. Behaviour, Attendance and Inclusion

- **Provide strategic leadership** for the academy's pastoral vision and behaviour culture, ensuring it is developmentally appropriate and promotes positive behaviour in young children.
- **Line manage relevant staff** to ensure a proactive and supportive approach to attendance and welfare, with a focus on early intervention and support for families.
- **Oversee analysis and reporting of behaviour and attendance data**, using it to inform targeted interventions and monitor impact, with a particular emphasis on identifying patterns and trends in early years and key stage 1.
- **Lead staff development in behaviour management** strategies and promote consistency through policies, ensuring these strategies are age-appropriate, positive, and promote self-regulation in young children.
- **Collaborate with external agencies and internal teams** to support vulnerable pupils and ensure inclusive practice, with a strong focus on early identification of SEND and effective support for diverse learning needs in the primary classroom.
- **Respond effectively to incidents and behavioural issues** – including those related to transition to and from the academy – ensuring safety and dignity are upheld, with a particular sensitivity to the needs of young children.

3. Learning, Teaching and Assessment

- **Provide strategic leadership** for a key area of academy improvement, ensuring the curriculum meets the diverse needs of learners and supports outstanding outcomes, with a focus on delivering a broad, balanced, and engaging primary curriculum.
- **Ensure teaching and learning** policies are consistently embedded and that classroom practice reflects the highest standards of primary pedagogy, including effective differentiation, formative assessment, and active learning.
- **Use data incisively to monitor progress**, identify trends, and support teaching staff in delivering impactful interventions, with a focus on using assessment data to inform teaching and learning in the classroom.
- **Lead on the review and evaluation** of pupil tracking systems and assessment frameworks to ensure accuracy, clarity, and usefulness in measuring progress and attainment.
- **Oversee teaching quality within designated subject areas**, carrying out lesson observations, learning walks, and work scrutiny, with a focus on providing constructive feedback to improve primary teaching practice.

- **Focus on high prior attaining pupils (HAPs)**, ensuring they are challenged and stretched to reach their full potential, while also providing appropriate support and extension activities for all learners in the primary classroom.

4. Staff Development and Leadership

- **Model exemplary leadership behaviours**, fostering a professional, optimistic and ambitious school culture, with a focus on creating a collaborative and supportive environment for staff.
- **Exercise effective line management and performance development**, providing constructive feedback and recognising achievement, while also supporting the wellbeing of primary staff.
- **Sustain motivation and morale across teams**, supporting wellbeing and cultivating a collegiate environment, where primary staff feel valued and supported in their professional development.
- **Contribute to talent management**, supporting staff development pathways and succession planning, with a focus on developing future leaders in primary education.
- **Deliver and contribute to CPD and INSET programmes** that build staff capacity and deepen professional expertise, specifically tailored to the needs of primary teachers and support staff.
- **Uphold the academy's vision and values** through strong professional relationships and visible leadership, building trust and respect among primary staff, pupils, and parents.

5. Resource and Operations Management

- **Work with the Principal, Governors, and Director of Finance and Operations** to secure and deploy resources strategically and efficiently, ensuring they are used to maximise the impact on pupil learning.
- **Support in the recruitment, retention, and deployment of staff** to ensure a high-quality learning environment, with a focus on recruiting and retaining excellent primary teachers and support staff.
- **Oversee accommodation and facilities** to ensure they are safe, well-maintained, and fit for purpose for young children, creating a stimulating and engaging learning environment.
- **Support budget planning and management** to ensure value for money and alignment with curriculum needs and school priorities, with a focus on allocating resources effectively to support primary education.

6. Raising Standards and Academic Outcomes

- **Ensure systematic reviews of standards are embedded** across the academy, enabling timely interventions and continual improvement in primary education.
- **Work closely with senior and middle leaders to monitor progress** within their areas and hold them to account for outcomes, with a focus on ensuring that all pupils make good progress in the primary phase.
- **Motivate pupils and staff alike** to strive for excellence, celebrating achievement and driving ambition in the primary school community.

- **Embed a culture of continuous improvement** through clear expectations, milestone tracking, and data-led strategies, with a focus on using data to inform school improvement planning in the primary setting.
- Use whole-school platforms such as assemblies to promote aspiration, resilience, and pupil voice, creating a positive and inclusive ethos in the primary academy.

7. Community and Partnerships

- **Represent the academy** at Governor meetings, public events and community engagements, acting as an advocate for primary education and the needs of young children.
- **Ensure Citizenship and Spiritual, Moral, Social and Cultural (SMSC)** development is integrated into all aspects of school life, promoting British Values and preparing pupils for life in modern Britain.
- **Build strong partnerships** with families, external agencies and local stakeholders to enhance pupil experience and support inclusion, with a focus on engaging parents in their children's learning and supporting families.
- **Act as an ambassador for the Trust and the academy**, maintaining a visible and proactive presence in the wider community, promoting the value of primary education and the achievements of the school.



Person Specification – Vice Principal

This section outlines the essential and desirable attributes expected for the role of Vice Principal (Primary).

Qualifications and Training

Essential:

- 'O' Level/GCSE A–C pass grade/new grade Level 4–9 in English & Mathematics.
- Bachelor's degree in any subject (ideally, 2:2 or better).
- DfE recognised Qualified Teacher Status.

Desirable:

- Further degree.
- Accredited post graduate study, Masters/MBA, NPQSL.
- Sustained record of professional development with a focus on primary education.
- Management Training

Experience

Essential:

- Proven record of significant senior leadership achievement in a primary school.
- Proven track record of raising standards in a primary setting.
- Experience of management of human and financial resources at a senior level.
- Proven behaviour leadership in a primary environment.
- Successful establishment of links with the local community.
- Excellent track record as an effective innovator of education in a primary setting.

Desirable:

- Successful experience of promoting equal opportunities, inclusion and appropriate strategies for children with special educational needs in a primary school.
- Experience of developing pupil involvement in schools.
- Experience of working with parents in a primary setting.
- Experience of child safeguarding issues and successful use of measures that promote and ensure the safeguarding of young people.

- Experience of using performance management processes successfully to contribute to school improvement.
- Experience at deputy head level or equivalent in a primary school.
- Experience of working within a MAT.
- Experience of developing SEN at a strategic level in a primary setting.

Knowledge and Understanding

Essential:

- Ability to use data to analyse performance and manage interventions.
- Understands how to plan lessons with challenging learning objectives and outcomes appropriate to primary education.
- Understanding of Assessment for Learning in the primary phase.
- Effective use of ICT to promote learning.
- Understands the factors affecting learning in primary-aged children.
- A thorough understanding of primary pedagogy and the developmental needs of young children.
- Understanding of e-learning.
- Strategies to maintain good behaviour and pace in a primary setting.
- Strategies for monitoring and evaluation of standards of attainment in primary education.
- Effective development of staff and resources.

Desirable:

- Familiarity with the Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS) curriculum and its transition to Key Stage 1 & 2.
- Understanding of the Primary Years Programme (PYP)
- Knowledge of leading assessment systems across the primary age range.

Skills

Essential:

- An Outstanding classroom teacher in the primary phase.
- Proven leadership skills including a range of leadership styles as required.
- Effective behaviour management in a primary setting.
- Strategic management, resource management, development planning & personnel management
- Effective interpretation, analysis and use of data
- Well-developed coaching and mentoring skills
- Well-developed interpersonal and communication skills (including written, oral and presentation)
- Wide experience of managing change, leading innovations and meeting challenges successfully
- Effective ICT Skills

Personal Qualities

The individual demonstrates **presence, drive, and a passion for raising standards** for all in the pursuit of excellence, showing a strong desire to improve outcomes for all pupils and a **commitment to high standards** in primary education. They share the vision of the academy and its sponsors, aligning with and supporting their goals. With the ability to **both lead and work collaboratively**, they effectively **spearhead initiatives** while contributing as a **valued team member**. They approach **problem-solving** with a strong, **solution-focused mindset**, taking **proactive and analytical steps** to overcome challenges. **Energetic, resilient, and empathetic**, they display enthusiasm, recover quickly from setbacks, and show **compassion and understanding** towards others, particularly the needs of young children. They are skilled in **developing and maintaining positive relationships** with staff, parents, pupils, governors, and the wider community. Committed to continuous improvement, they actively **seek opportunities for professional development** and strive to enhance academy practices. Their ability to **plan and prioritise** ensures that tasks are **well-organised and deadlines met**, while their **attention to detail** reflects accuracy and thoroughness in all aspects of work. **Innovative and self-reflective**, they generate new ideas and critically assess their own performance. They handle conflicts and sensitive issues with pupils, parents, and staff with tact and diplomacy, **staying calm under pressure** and maintaining a **balanced perspective and good humour** throughout.

Safeguarding of students and Duty of care

All staff, regardless of role, level of seniority and location, have a responsibility to ensure the highest levels of safeguarding and promoting the welfare of our pupils, and we expect all our staff and volunteers to share this commitment. We must collectively create an environment where children feel safe to learn, play, and grow. Children should feel comfortable in their surroundings and know that they can approach any responsible adult with any problems or concerns.

All staff must be able to identify any children who are at risk of harm, and know the characteristics of abuse or neglect. If you suspect or confirm harm then it's essential you know what actions to take.

Annual safeguarding training is offered to all staff at Leigh Academies Trust, and it is the staff member's responsibility to be aware of the most up to date guidance documented in the [Keeping Children Safe in Education document](#) ([Department of Education](#)).

Notes

The job description allocates duties and responsibilities but does not direct the particular amount of time to be spent on carrying them out and no part of it may be so construed. This job description is not necessarily a comprehensive definition of the post. It will be reviewed at least once a year and may be subject to modification or amendment at any time after consultation with the holder of the post.

The duties may be varied to meet the changing demands of the academy/business unit at the reasonable discretion of the Principal/Academies Director. This job description does not form part of the contract of employment. It describes the way the post-holder is expected and required to perform and complete the particular duties as set out in the foregoing.

